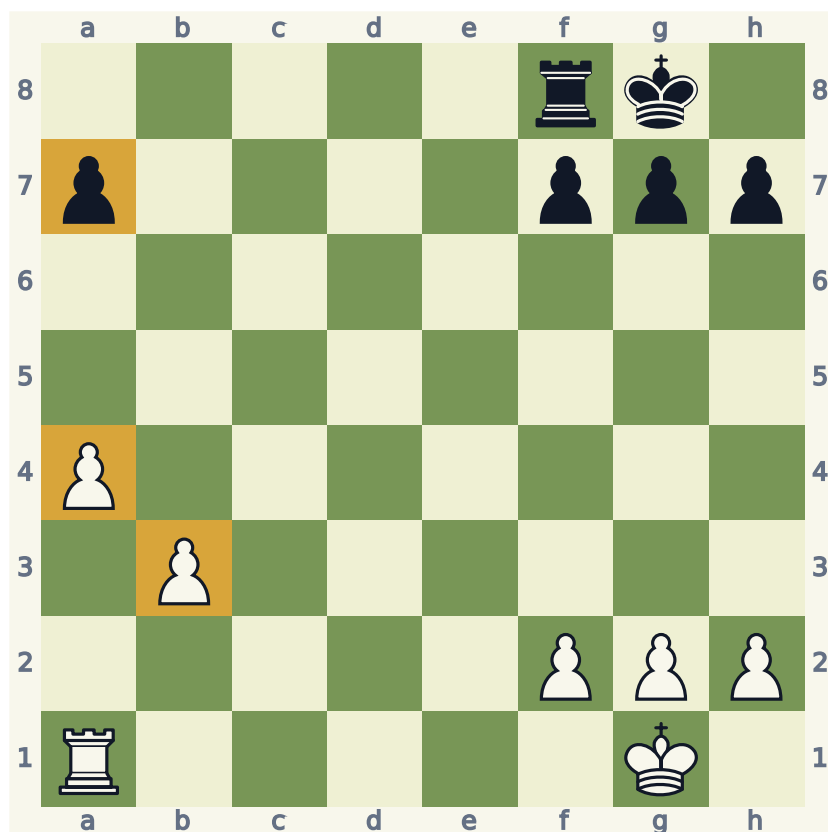


Pawn majorities and passed pawns

Create a passer without surrendering control.

A pawn majority can create a passed pawn by exchanging opposing pawns. A passed pawn has no enemy pawn ahead of it on its own or an adjacent file. Its value depends on support, the blockade square and king activity. A mobile majority is more useful than a larger but immobilized group.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- White has two queenside pawns against one.
- The a4-pawn can recapture on b5.
- The resulting b-pawn will have no enemy pawn in front of it on the a-, b- or c-file.

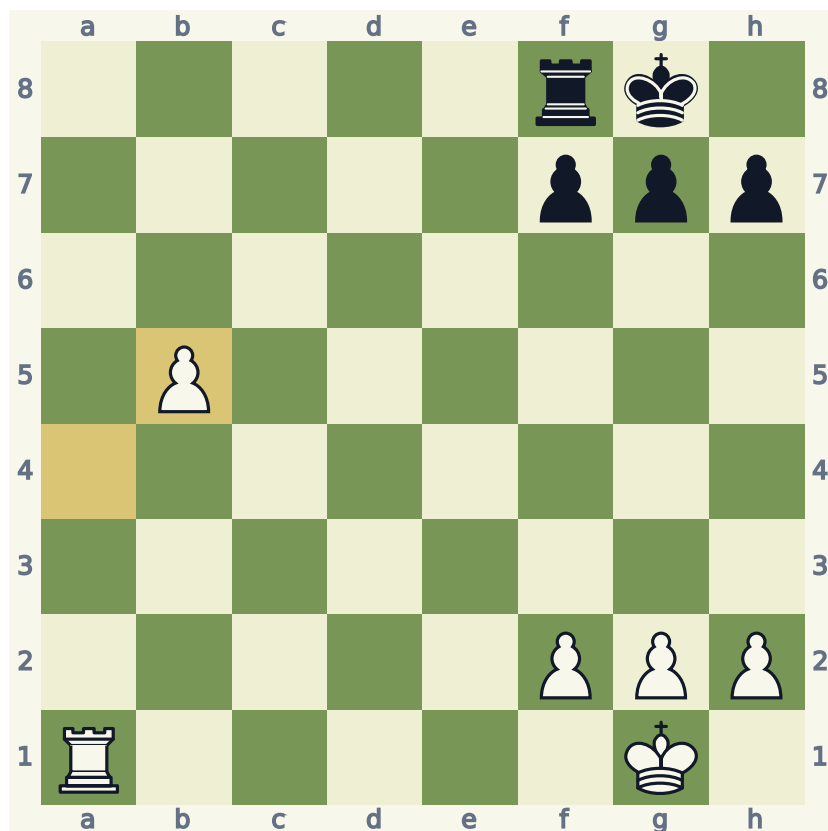
REMEMBER

- Verify the passed-pawn definition.
- Mobilize the majority with supported exchanges.
- Coordinate before pushing beyond protection.

Follow the logic

1. b4 a6 2. b5 axb5 3. axb5

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



b4 ...a6

White prepares to mobilize the majority while Black holds it back. Keep the recapture structure in mind.

b5 ...axb5

White offers an exchange that removes the only opposing queenside pawn.

axb5

The a-pawn becomes a passed b-pawn. It still needs support; creating a passer is a strategic milestone, not an automatic win.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black should seek an active rook, checking chances and a blockade in front of the passer. White should coordinate rook and king rather than push the pawn so far that it becomes undefended.

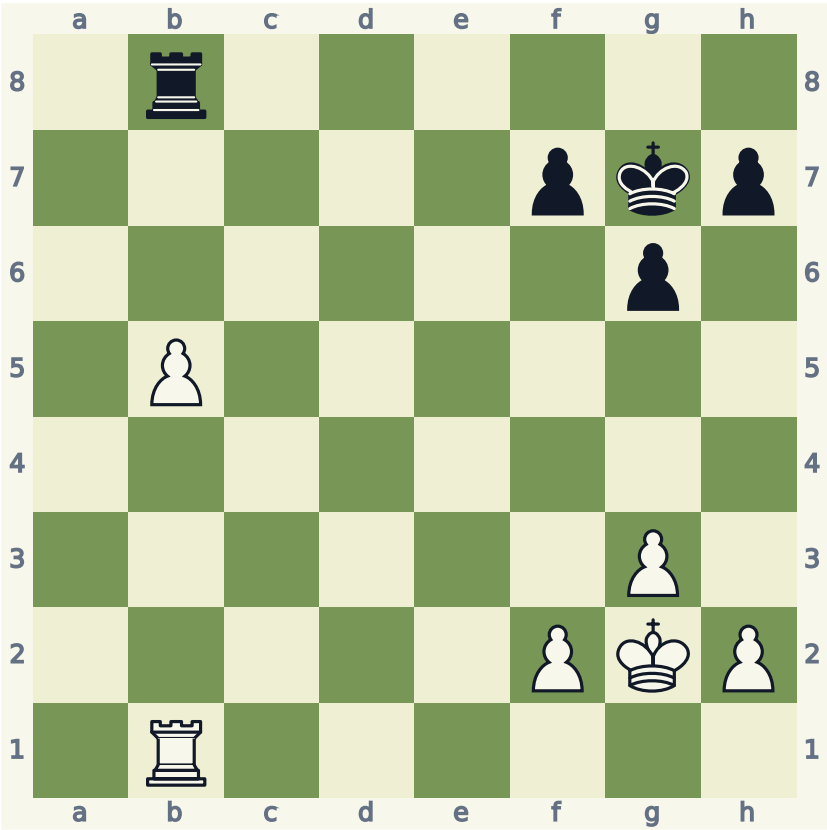
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Count the race concretely. A distant passer can distract the king, but an enemy king or rook may stop it easily. Rooks often work well behind passed pawns, yet checking geometry can justify another placement.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Why is b5 a passed pawn?
- 2. Why is b6 not the only plan to consider?
- 3. What does the king maneuver add?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If Black had a pawn on c7, would the b5-pawn still be passed?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 1r6/5pkp/6p1/1P6/8/6P1/5PKP/1R6 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. Black has no a-, b- or c-pawn ahead of b5. The rook on b8 can block or attack it, but pieces do not change the definition of a passed pawn.
2. Pushing may shorten the distance to promotion but can also make the pawn easier to blockade. White should compare improving the king, activating the rook and advancing only when support is adequate.
3. Kf3 and Ke4 bring the king toward the center. From there it can support further progress or switch toward the kingside. The sample is a planning illustration; Black will also seek active rook checks.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Kf3 Kf6 2. Ke4

Changed feature: No. An enemy c7-pawn is ahead on an adjacent file and can influence the b-pawn's route. It must be removed or bypassed before calling b5 a passer.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Set up the exercise. Try advancing immediately, then try centralizing the king first. Compare how easily the defending rook creates checks.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 19, 22, 24. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.